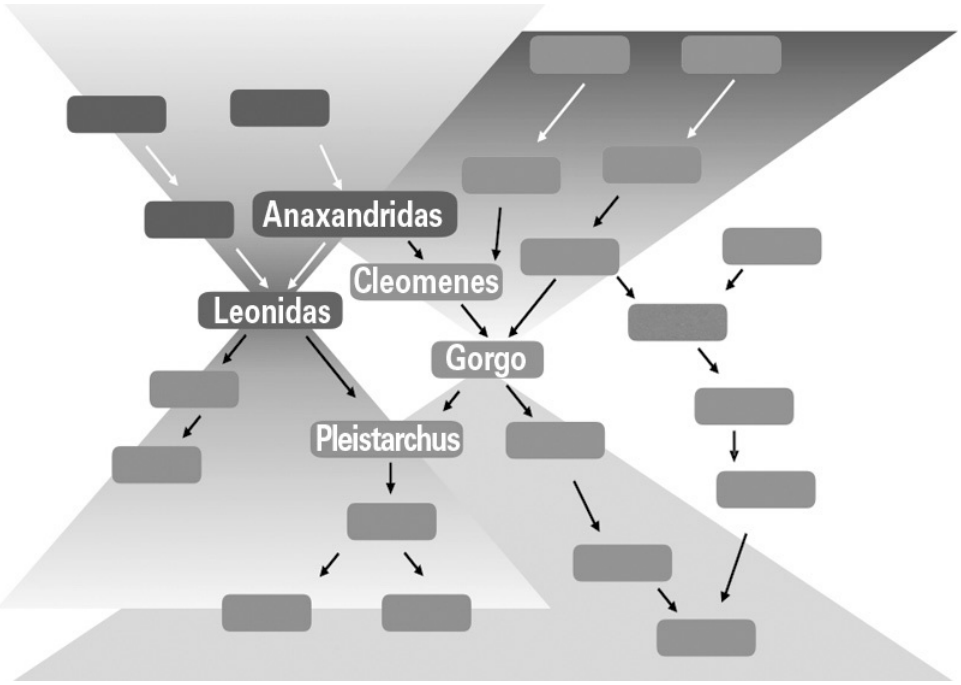


The temporal structure of the universe is very similar to this one. It is also made of cones. The relation of “temporal precedence” is a partial order made of cones.[31] Special relativity is the discovery that the temporal structure of the universe is like the one established by filiation: it defines an order between the events of the universe that is *partial*, not *complete*. The expanded present is the set of events that are neither past nor future: it exists, just as there are human beings who are neither our descendants nor our forebears.

If we want to represent all the events in the universe and their temporal relations, we can no longer do so with a single, universal distinction between past, present, and future, like this:

We must do so instead by placing above and below every event the cones of its future and past events: